

Maamarei Mordechai

הסבר לפי ממש פשוט

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D. Mordechai Schlachter

Listen to the Navi, but only the true Navi.

נָבִיא מִקִּרְבְּךָ מֵאַחֶיךָ כָּמֹנִי יָקִים לְךָ יְהוָה אֱלֹהֶיךָ אֵלָיו תִּשְׁמָעוּ:

“A prophet from among you, from your brethren, like me, Hashem your God will raise up for you; to him you shall heed.” (Devarim 18:15)

Why does the pasuk say “from your brethren” if it already said “from among you?” Also, if no navi will ever be like Moshe (ibid. 34:10), then how can this navi be like Moshe?

The Torah lays out the highest levels of national authority: the Sanhedrin (supreme court), the king, the Kohanim and Leviim, and then the prophet. The placement of these laws is not accidental. The Torah places the discussion of prophecy after the laws of the king, but before the laws of cities of refuge, witnesses, and warfare. This order teaches a fundamental principle about Jewish leadership.

After introducing the king, the Torah gives his limitations. There must be a voice within Bnei Yisroel that reminds the nation – and even its leaders – that they are servants of a higher authority. One would think that the king would be mentioned last, as the highest authority. Instead, the Torah places the navi last. His is the voice that carries the greatest weight. The navi's role is to preserve Bnei Yisroel's relationship with Hashem and to guide the nation in fulfilling the Torah.

The Torah defines the prophet in three ways: he comes from among Bnei Yisroel, he is a brother, and he is like Moshe. The additional phrase, “from your brethren,” is especially significant. The Torah uses the word “brother” to refer to a fellow member of Bnei Yisroel, not simply another human being. When discussing the appointment of a king, the Torah says, “From among your brethren you shall appoint a king over yourself.” (Ibid. 17:15). The Torah immediately clarifies that this means, “You may not place over yourself a foreign man who is not your brother.” (Ibid.). The Torah also says regarding lending, “You shall not charge interest to your brother... but to the stranger you may charge interest.” (Ibid. 23:20–21). Regarding indentured servitude, it says, “When your brother becomes impoverished with you.” (Vayikra 25:39). It then contrasts this with servants acquired from the nations. (Ibid. 25:44). In each of these cases, the Torah shows that a “brother” is a member of Bnei Yisroel.

The Torah uses similar language in our pasuk, qualifying “brethren” with “from among you.” Given that the Torah's understanding has already been made clear by these other verses, what additional lesson is taught? Our pasuk does not exclude a non-Jew from receiving Divine messages. The Torah itself records that Avimelech received a Divine revelation (Bereishis 20:6), and Balaam received prophetic communication (Bamidbar 22–24). Pharaoh received prophetic dreams, as did Nevuchadnezzar. However, these examples demonstrate the distinction. A person may receive a message

from Hashem, but that does not make him the navi appointed to guide Bnei Yisroel. The Torah's promise is specifically about a prophet who stands within the nation and continues the mission of Moshe.

The Torah calls him a “brother” because he is like a family member whose only intention is to help, guide, and protect. His motives are to promote the family's values. Even if he is from a different tribe, he is still a brother, and his message comes from a shared Father. This excludes a foreigner living as a sojourner in Eretz Yisroel. It also excludes another member of Klal Yisroel whose motives are skewed.

The words “like me” further define the navi's role. Moshe was not merely a miracle worker or a predictor of the future. Moshe was the teacher of Torah. His entire mission was to transmit Hashem's commandments: “You shall speak to him all that I command you.” (Shemos 7:2). The prophet who follows Moshe must therefore have the same fundamental purpose, to communicate Hashem's will without changing the Torah. It does not mean a navi as powerful or as connected to Hashem as Moshe. Such a navi will never exist again. Rather, it means a navi who carries out the prophetic mission with the same integrity and fidelity to Hashem's word as Moshe.

The Torah provides a warning immediately before and after the laws of prophecy. A prophet is not validated merely by miracles. The Torah says that even if a prophet provides a sign, if he attempts to lead Bnei Yisroel away from the Torah, then “you shall not listen to that prophet.” (Devarim 13:4). The reason is that the Torah itself is eternal and is the paradigm by which all other holy books are judged. “You shall not add to the word that I command you, nor subtract from it.” (Devarim 4:2). A true navi may clarify, warn, encourage, and guide, but he cannot create a new Torah or abolish an existing commandment.

This also explains the placement of prophecy within the order of the Torah. After describing governors and kings—the legislators who interpret the Torah and the executives who enforce compliance with the Torah—the Torah teaches that every human authority must answer to Hashem. Before discussing the implementation of the Torah through cities of refuge, witnesses, and warfare, the Torah establishes the spiritual safeguard that protects the nation. Bnei Yisroel must always have a messenger who calls it back to its covenant with Hashem. Governors apply the Torah to everyday life and kings enforce their rulings, but human beings can err, and the nation can fall into a pattern of laxity or misguided zeal. The navi is that safeguard who guides the king, the governors, and the people back to the proper path.

The king governs the nation, the judge administers justice, and the prophet reminds them all that they stand beneath a higher authority. The true prophet is therefore not an innovator who changes Torah practice; he is the guardian who ensures that Bnei Yisroel never abandons the Torah. He can guide when to wage war, when to offer peace, when to repent, and forewarn when danger is imminent. The navi is much more than a recipient of Divine prophecy. There is an interpersonal connection between him and the nation, and has a personal stake in its survival, that makes him indispensable. Otherwise, Hashem could just as well send a malakh to do the job. The human touch makes both the message and the messenger compelling.